

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Senate Democrats admonish FBI chief

Patel rejects critics' charge that agency focused on revenge

By Eric Tucker
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — FBI Director Kash Patel clashed with skeptical Democrats at a contentious Senate oversight hearing Tuesday, defending his record amid criticism that he has politicized the nation's premier federal law enforcement agency and pursued retribution against perceived adversaries of President Donald Trump.

"Mr. Patel, in just eight months, you have assaulted the institutional integrity of the FBI," said Democratic Sen. Cory Booker of New Jersey, in one of several testy exchanges between Patel and lawmakers.

The appearance Tuesday before the Senate Judiciary Committee represented the first oversight hearing of Patel's young but tumultuous tenure and provided a high-stakes platform for him to try to demonstrate that he is the right person for the job

at a time of internal upheaval and mounting concerns about political violence inside the United States, a threat laid bare by last week's killing of conservative activist Charlie Kirk at a college campus in Utah.

Patel, backed by Republican lawmakers who signaled their support for him, sought to keep the focus on what he said was a series of accomplishments in fighting violent crime, protecting children from abuse and disrupting the flow of fentanyl. He boasted Tuesday that the man suspected in Kirk's killing was arrested within 33 hours but also faced questions over confusion he caused soon after the killing when he posted on social media that "the subject" was in custody. That person was later released after investigators determined he had no connection.

"Could I have been more careful in my verbiage and included 'a' subject instead of 'the' subject? Sure," Patel said.

Democrats, for their part, repeatedly tried to steer the hearing back to the turmoil inside the FBI and suggested his firing of experienced agents and supervisors was a troubling about-face

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Federal agents hang off the back of a military-style vehicle as they, along with several other vehicles, drive south along Chippewa Drive on Tuesday in Elgin. Agents broke down doors of a nearby home and detained several people. STACEY WESCOTT/CHICAGO TRIBUNE PHOTOS

US citizen briefly detained in latest immigration blitz

Elgin man says he was handcuffed, questioned; DHS releases info on 11 arrested

By Angie Leventis Lourgos,
Jeremy Gerner
and Stacey Wescott
Chicago Tribune

An Elgin man who was born in the United States said he was handcuffed, questioned and placed in a U.S. Customs and Border Protection vehicle before dawn, part of a blitz of immigration enforcement activity reported in the Chicago area early Tuesday.

Joe Botello, 37, recalled being jolted awake before 6 a.m. by his home shaking and the sounds of yelling upstairs on the main floor.

He said masked and armed agents were calling out the name of another man in Spanish and had forcibly entered his house in the 900 block of Chippewa Drive, destroying a front door and glass patio door in the process.

"I'm just blessed that I'm still alive," Botello said. "I've been hearing it and seeing it through social media. But it never crossed my mind that it was going to happen here at the house ...



Ismael Cordova-Clough, left, hugs Delani Hernandez, both members of a volunteer patrol group in the Elgin area, as Hernandez cries after witnessing a man pulled from his truck and detained by federal agents along Route 31 on Tuesday in Elgin.

where I live."

Department of Homeland Security Secretary Kristi Noem shared a video on social media of four men — including Botello — handcuffed and being led away

from the home.

Noem appears to hop on a truck at the end of the clip, but she is not shown interacting with any of the detainees. Neither the video nor Noem's message

IN CHICAGOLAND: Gov. JB Pritzker says President Donald Trump is "losing it" after the latest threat to send National Guard to Chicago. **Page 3**

explain that Botello is a U.S. citizen and was later released.

"I was on the ground in Chicago today to make clear we are not backing down," Noem posted on X as she shared a video of herself in Elgin. "Just this morning, DHS took violent offenders off the streets with arrests for assault, DUI and felony stalking. Our work is only beginning"

Meanwhile, the Department of Homeland Security on Tuesday released information on 11 more men arrested since "Operation Midway Blitz" began, though there were no details provided on exactly where or when the arrests occurred. All of the detainees were in the U.S. illegally, the DHS said.

Turn to Blitz, Page 2

High housing costs force some to delay having kids



Regeant Panday and Sarah Tang in their living room as Tang holds onto Kaali, one of their two cats, in their Bridgeport neighborhood home on July 17. The couple bought their house nearly a year ago. While they were able to achieve homeownership, it has come with sacrifices for the couple, ones that many Americans are having to make because of climbing housing costs. CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

"Ideally having children is a joyous thing where you have a partner and decide you want to grow your family. But the financial piece is going to be a backstop to diving into that with less anxiety." — Sarah Tang

By Lizzie Kane
Chicago Tribune

Sarah Tang and Regeant Panday were following what many consider the path to the American Dream: college, marriage, house, kids. Tang's parents followed that formula. Her dad pushed her to do the same.

"You need to buy a house to grow up," Tang remembered thinking.

The couple decided to forgo a more expensive wedding and reception, opting instead for City Hall nuptials and a small dinner with friends. With savings and some family help, the millennial couple pieced together the roughly \$110,000 needed for a down payment last summer on a three-bedroom Bridgeport home.

While Tang, 31, and Panday, 38, were able to achieve homeownership, it has left them "house poor": spending an outsized portion of their income on homeownership. As a result, they've had to make sacrifices. They delayed buying a car. They cut back on dining out. They limit their grocery spending, shopping primarily at Aldi, a chain known

Turn to Costs, Page 4

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ABEL URIBE/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Star of '70s films turned director and liberal activist

Robert Redford, the Hollywood golden boy who became an Oscar-winning director, liberal activist and champion of independent cinema died Tuesday. He was 89. **Nation & World inside Business, Page 5**

'Disciplined, focused and determined'

Illini outside linebacker Gabe Jacas is determined to keep rising — for his team, his family and eventually his future. **Chicago Sports**

